DIALECTICS: Walking the Middle Path SESSION 10

Validation
Self-Validation
Behaviourism

Validation

VALIDATION MEANS:

- Finding the kernel of truth in another person's perspective or situation; verifying the facts of a situation.
- Acknowledging that a person's emotions, thoughts, and behaviors have causes and are therefore understandable.
- *Not* necessarily agreeing with the other person.
- *Not* validating what is actually invalid.

WHY VALIDATE?

- It improves our relationships by showing we are listening and understand.
- It improves interpersonal effectiveness by reducing:
    1. Pressure to prove who is right
    2. Negative reactivity
    3. Anger
- It makes problem solving, closeness, and support possible.
- Invalidation hurts.

IMPORTANT THINGS TO VALIDATE

- The valid (and *only* the valid).
- The facts of a situation.
- A person's experiences, feelings/emotions, beliefs, opinions, or thoughts about something.
- Suffering and difficulties.

REMEMBER:

- Every invalid response makes sense in some way.
- Validation is not necessarily agreeing.
- Validation doesn't mean you like it.
- Only validate the valid!

A "How To" Guide to Validation

1. ❑ **Pay Attention:**
Look interested, listen, and observe. No multitasking. Make eye contact. Stay focused. Nod occasionally. Respond with your face (e.g., smile at happy statements; look concerned when hearing something painful).

2. ❑ **Reflect Back:**
Say back what you heard or observed to be sure you actually understand what the person is saying. *No* judgmental language or voice tone!

Try to really "get" what the person feels or thinks. Have an open mind. (No disagreeing, criticizing, or trying to change the person's mind or goals.) Use a voice tone that allows the other person to correct you . . . and *check the facts!*

Example: *"So you are mad at me because you think I lied just to get back at you. Did I get it right?"*

3. ❑ **"Read Minds":**
Be sensitive to what is *not* being said by the other person. Pay attention to facial expressions, body language, what is happening, and what you know about the person already. Show that you understand in words or by your actions. *Be open to correction.*

Example: *When you are asking a friend for a ride at the end of a long day and the person slumps down, say, "You look really tired. Let me look for someone else."*

4. ❑ **Understand:**
Look for how the other person feels, is thinking, or if he or she is making sense, given the person's history, state of mind or body, or current events (i.e. the causes)—even if you don't approve of the person's behavior, or if his or her belief is incorrect. Say *"It makes sense that you . . . because . . . "*

Example: *If you sent a party invitation to the wrong address, say, "I can see why you thought I might be excluding you on purpose."*

5. ❑ **Acknowledge the valid:**
Show that you see that the person's thoughts, feelings, or actions are valid, given current reality and facts. Act as if the person's behavior is valid.

Example: *If you are criticized for not taking out the garbage on your day, admit that it is your day and take it out. If people present a problem, help them solve it (unless they just want to be heard). If people are hungry, give them food. Acknowledge the effort a person is making.*

6. ❑ **Show Equality:**
Be yourself! Don't "one-up" or "one-down" the other person. Treat the other as an equal, not as fragile or incompetent.

Example: *Be willing to admit mistakes. If someone introduces themselves by first name, introduce yourself by your first name. Ask other people for their opinions. Give up being defensive. Be careful in giving advice or telling someone what to do if you are not asked or required to do so. Even then, remember you could be wrong.*

Note. Adapted from Linehan, M. M. (1997). Validation and psychotherapy. In A. Bohart & L. Greenberg (Eds.), *Empathy reconsidered: New directions in psychotherapy* (pp. 353–392). Washington, DC: American Psychological Association. Copyright 1997 by the American Psychological Association. Adapted by permission.

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Strategies for Increasing the Probability of Behaviors You Want

Describe behaviors for yourself or others that you would like to start or increase:

_____

Reinforcer = A consequence that increases frequency of a behavior.

Positive reinforcement = positive consequences (i.e., reward).

Behavior is increased by consequences a person wants, likes, or will work to get.

Examples: _____

Negative reinforcement = removal of negative events (i.e., relief).

Behavior is increased by consequences that stop or reduce something negative.

Examples: _____

Shaping = Reinforcing small steps toward the behavior you want.

- Reinforce small steps that lead toward the goal.
- As new behavior stabilizes, require a little bit more before reinforcing.
- Continue until you reach the goal behavior.

Examples of steps to a goal behavior: _____

_____

Timing counts.

- Reinforce behavior immediately after it occurs.
- When shaping new behavior, at first reinforce every instance of the behavior.
- Once behavior is established, gradually start to reinforce only some of the time.

CAUTION: When you vary reinforcement, behavior becomes *very* hard to stop.

Strategies for Decreasing or Stopping Unwanted Behaviors

Extinction = Stopping an ongoing reinforcement of behavior.

Extinction leads first to a burst of behavior, and then to a decrease in behavior.

Examples: _____

Satiation = Providing relief or what is wanted *before* the behavior occurs.

Satiation reduces motivation for behavior and thus decreases its frequency.

Examples: _____

Punishment = An aversive consequence that decreases a behavior.

Behavior is decreased by consequences the person dislikes or will work to avoid.

Examples: _____

Behavior is decreased by consequences that stop or reduce something positive.

Examples: _____

Behavior is decreased when something the person wants is withheld until harmful effects of problem behaviors are corrected and overcorrected.

Examples: _____

- Be sure that punishment is specific, is time-limited, and fits the "crime."
- Avoid a punitive tone; let the consequence do the work.
- If a natural punishment occurs, don't undo it. Don't add arbitrary punishment.

Be sure to reinforce alternative behavior to replace behavior you want stopped.

- Extinction and punishment weaken or suppress behavior, but do not eliminate it.
- Extinction and punishment do not teach new behavior.
- To keep a behavior from resurfacing, reinforce an alternative behavior.
- Punishment works only when the punisher is (or is likely to be) present.
- Punishment leads to avoidance of the person punishing.

Tips for Using Behavior Change Strategies Effectively

Summary so far:

Goal		Consequence
Increase behavior	(Reinforce)	• Add positive consequence • Remove aversive consequence
Weaken behavior	(Extinguish)	• Remove reinforcer • Provide relief *before* unwanted behavior
Suppress behavior	(Punish)	• Add aversive consequence • Remove positive consequence

Not all consequences are created equal.

"One person's poison can be another person's passion."

Context counts. A reinforcer in one situation can be punishment in another.

Quantity counts. If a reinforcer is too little or too much, it will not work.

Natural consequences work best. Let them do the work when possible.

Ask what consequence the person would work to get (reinforcer) or work to avoid (punisher).

Observe changes in behavior when a consequence is applied.

Behavior learned in one situation may not happen in another situation.

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Validating Others

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Fill out this sheet whenever you practice your validation skills and whenever you have an opportunity to practice even if you don't (or almost don't) do anything to practice.

Check off types of validation that you practiced (on purpose) with others:

- ❑ 1. Paid attention.
- ❑ 2. Reflected back what was said or done, remaining open to correction.
- ❑ 3. Was sensitive to what was unsaid.
- ❑ 4. Expressed how what was felt, done, or said made sense, given the causes.
- ❑ 5. Acknowledged and acted on what was valid.
- ❑ 6. Acted authentically and as an equal.

List one invalidating and two validating statements made to others.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Describe a situation where you were nonjudgmental of someone in the past week.

_____

_____

_____

Describe a situation where you used validation in the past week.

_____

_____

_____

Who was the person you validated? _____

What exactly did you do or say to validate the person? _____

_____

_____

What was the outcome? _____

_____

_____

How did you feel afterward? _____

Would you say or do something differently next time? If so, what? _____

_____

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Self-Validation and Self-Respect

Due Date:_____Name:_____Week Starting: _____

Fill out this sheet whenever you practice your self-validation skills and whenever you have an opportunity to practice even if you don't (or almost don't) do anything to practice.

List one self-invalidating and two self-validating statements you made.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Describe a situation where you felt invalidated in the past week: _____

_____

_____

Check each strategy you used during the week:

- ☐ Checked *all* the facts to see if my responses are valid or invalid.
- ☐ Checked it out with someone I could trust to validate the valid.
- ☐ Acknowledged when my responses didn't make sense and were not valid.
- ☐ Worked to change invalid thinking, comments, or actions. (Stopped blaming.)
- ☐ Dropped judgmental self-statements. (Practiced opposite action.)
- ☐ Reminded myself that all behavior is caused and that I am doing my best.
- ☐ Was compassionate toward myself. Practiced self-soothing.
- ☐ Admitted that it hurts to be invalidated by others, even if they are right.
- ☐ Acknowledged when my reactions make sense and are valid in a situation.
- ☐ Remembered that being invalidated, even when my response is actually valid, is rarely a complete catastrophe.
- ☐ Described my experiences and actions in a supportive environment. Grieved traumatic invalidation in my life and the harm it has created.
- ☐ Practiced radical acceptance of the invalidating person(s) in my life.

What was the outcome? _____

_____

Recovering from Invalidation

NOTICE THAT INVALIDATION CAN BE HELPFUL AND PAINFUL AT THE SAME TIME

Remember:
Invalidation Is Helpful When

1. It corrects important mistakes (your facts are wrong).
2. It stimulates intellectual and personal growth by listening to other views.

Invalidation Is Painful When

1. You are being ignored.
2. You are being repeatedly misunderstood.
3. You are being misread.
4. You are being misinterpreted.
5. Important facts in your life are ignored or denied.
6. You are receiving unequal treatment.
7. You are being disbelieved when being truthful.
8. Your private experiences are trivialized or denied.
9. Other: _____

(*continued on next page*)

Be Nondefensive and Check the Facts

- Check ALL the facts to see if your responses are valid or invalid. Check them out with someone you can trust to validate the valid.
- Acknowledge when your responses don't make sense and are not valid.
- Work to change invalid thinking, comments, or actions. (Also, stop blaming. It rarely helps a situation.)
- Drop judgmental self-statements. (Practice opposite action.)
- Remind yourself that all behavior is caused and that you are doing your best.
- Be compassionate toward yourself. Practice self-soothing.
- Admit that it hurts to be invalidated by others, even if they are right.
- Acknowledge when your reactions make sense and are valid in a situation.
- Remember that being invalidated, even when your response is actually valid, is rarely a complete catastrophe.
- Describe your experiences and actions in a supportive environment. Grieve traumatic invalidation and the harm it created.
- Practice radical acceptance of the invalidating person.

Validate Yourself Exactly the Way You Would Validate Someone Else

Changing Behavior with Reinforcement

Due Date:_____Name:_____Week Starting: _____

Fill out this sheet whenever you try to increase your own or someone else's behavior with reinforcement. Look for opportunities (since they occur all the time) to reinforce behavior.

1. In advance, identify the behavior you want to increase and the reinforcer you will use.

a. For yourself:

Behavior to increase: _____

Reinforcer: _____

b. For someone else:

Behavior to increase: _____

Reinforcer: _____

2. Describe the situation(s) where you used reinforcement.

a. For yourself: _____

b. For someone else: _____

3. What was the outcome? What did you observe?

a. For yourself: _____

_____

_____

_____

b. For someone else: _____

_____

_____

4. How did you feel afterward? _____

_____

5. Would you say or do something differently next time? If so, what? _____

_____

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